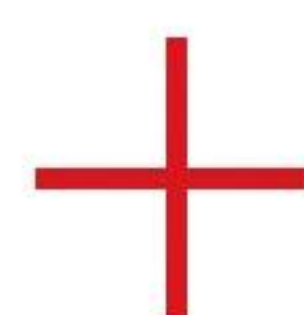




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Did you know?

Alex Pereira (left) honours his indigenous Brazilian roots every time he steps into the octagon.

He belongs to the Pataxó tribe and mimics firing a bow and arrow during his walkouts as a tribute to his ancestry. Growing up in a favela, Pereira dropped out of middle school to work in a tyre shop, struggling with severe alcoholism before discovering kickboxing at age 21.

Kai Asakura was equally impressive against Cameron Smotherman. Looking physically dominant at 135 pounds, Asakura dropped Smotherman with a clean right hand and sealed the knockout with a follow-up left hook at just 1:50 of Round 1.

Meanwhile, Jake Matthews put on a tactical masterclass against Carlston Harris. Matthews controlled the fight on both the feet and the canvas, earning a unanimous decision victory with scores of 30-25, 30-27 and 30-27. Of the card's four marquee fights, not one reached the third round, with three ending in the opening frame.

The biggest event yet

UFC Freedom 250 will kick off on June 14, as the first professional sporting event held on the South Lawn of the White House, commemorating America's 250th anniversary.

The main event features undefeated champion Ilia Topuria defending his lightweight title against Justin Gaethje. In the co-main event, Alex Pereira moves up to heavyweight to clash with Ciry Gane for the interim heavyweight belt. Other notable matchups include Sean O'Malley vs. Aiemann Zahabi and a heavyweight showdown between Derrick Lewis and Josh Hoki.

Notes from the cage

A round-up of the biggest UFC **talking points**, from Macau's explosive finishes to the White House spectacle awaiting Ilia Topuria, plus a lesser-known tale from Alex Pereira's journey.

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At UFC Fight Night in Macau, local hero Song Yadong sent the home crowd into a frenzy by securing a sensational second-round submission over former champion Deiveson Figueiredo.

After a highly competitive opening round, Song capitalised in the second. As Figueiredo attempted a takedown, 'The Kung Fu Kid' locked in a tight guillotine choke, forcing the tap at the 4:42 mark and firmly establishing himself as a top bantamweight contender.

Following the dramatic headliner, the co-main event featured a wild light heavyweight contest between Alonzo Menifield and Zhang Mingyang.

Both fighters traded heavy leather from the opening bell before Menifield secured a TKO victory via ground-and-pound at 4:15 of the first round.

In the heavyweight division, Sergei Pavlovich returned to form with a rapid victory over Tallison Teixeira. Pavlovich needed just 39 seconds to overwhelm his opponent, backing him up with a heavy right hand before closing the show with a barrage of strikes.